

WEEK ONE, IN ORDER

Learn the business before you learn the product

In your first week as a PM you get a wiki, a backlog and a calendar full of intros. Find a sales deck, not the internal wiki. Sales decks are written to explain the business to strangers, which is what you are.

Here's the order to read things in, and what to look for in each one.

1 The sales deck, twice

Ask whoever onboards you for the deck the team uses with new customers, rather than the internal strategy deck. You want the one a salesperson opens in front of somebody who has never heard of the company.

Read it twice before you read a single PRD: once for the story, and again for the claims, because your product has to keep every promise the deck makes.

EXAMPLE

List every claim in the deck. Then check which ones are in the backlog, and ask about the ones that aren't.

WHY THIS MATTERS: you will be asked to prioritize long before you understand the system, and the promises the company already made to customers are a list you can start from.

2 The pricing page

It's public and free. Pricing tells you what the company actually charges for, which isn't always what it says it sells.

Compare what's free with what's only in the most expensive tier. Customers are paying for the gap between the two.

EXAMPLE

Write one sentence: "We make money when a customer does X." If you can't finish it, you haven't found the business model yet, so keep looking.

WHY THIS MATTERS: product decisions that look irrational usually make sense once you understand the business model. Learn the money first and half the confusion disappears.

3 The last two quarterly updates

Quarterly updates show where the company wants to be versus where it is now. Look for two things: what leadership said would happen, and whether it did.

Also note anything that was in the first update and missing from the second, and ask about it in your next one to one.

EXAMPLE

List the metrics that show up in both updates, and find out which of them your team's work affects.

WHY THIS MATTERS: those are the numbers your work will be judged against, so you should know them before you pick your first project.

4 The org chart, then the real one

Get the org chart first so you know the names. Then work out who really decides things, which is often not what the chart says.

Watch who gets asked before a decision is made, whose objection stops something, and whose name comes up when nobody wants to say no directly.

EXAMPLE

After each intro meeting, write one line: who does this person need to hear from before they say yes? Put the lines in one doc and look for the names that show up again and again.

WHY THIS MATTERS: when you pitch your first project, you'll already know who needs to hear it before anyone else.

5 One recorded sales call

Ask sales for one recording of a call that went well and one that didn't.

You'll hear the customer describe the problem in their own words, and you'll hear which parts of your product they didn't care about at all.

EXAMPLE

Write down the exact phrases the customer used, and use them instead of the internal names in your first month of docs and updates.

WHY THIS MATTERS: in your first few meetings, the customer's own words are something you can bring that the team may not have heard in a while.

By week five you'll be able to tell whether the thing you're being asked to build makes any business sense.

Ask for the sales deck on your first day.